

After World War II, the Railway Board revisited its plan to electrify sections of four lines: Bombay–Ahmedabad of the Bombay, Baroda and Central India (BB&CI) Railway, Howrah–Mughalsarai of the East Indian Railway (EIR), and Igatpuri–Bhusaval and Poona–Dhond of the Great Indian Peninsula Railway (GIPR). The plan did not move forward, as India became independent soon after, bringing with it the bloodshed and pain of Partition. The question of electrification was relegated to the background and only became a matter of discussion a few years later.

First phase

By 1953, the Calcutta suburban system's terminal stations, Howrah and Sealdah, were operating beyond their capacity. A switch from steam to electric traction seemed to be the only way to increase efficiency and expand. Investigations to electrify Calcutta's tracks began as early as 1914, as industrialization led to an increase in suburban passengers. However, several political roadblocks – World War I, the Great Depression, and World War II – prevented further explorations until the early 1950s. The first subphase was sanctioned in 1954 for the Howrah–Burdwan main line of the Eastern Railway and the Seoraphuli–Tarakeswar branch line of the Howrah division. The electrification of the Howrah–Bandel section, including the branch line, took place in 1957. The Calcutta section used the DC (direct current) 3000 V system, which had proved quite beneficial in Europe, specifically Italy, as opposed to Bombay and Madras, which used the DC 1,500 V system.

Need of the hour

Electrification and dieselization became a matter of urgency with the Second Five Year Plan (1956–61), which prioritized industrialization, unlike the first plan (1951–56) that focused on rehabilitation. The east saw a visible change with this policy of industrial growth. Three new steel plants were set up at Rourkela, Odisha, Bhilai, Chhattisgarh, and Durgapur, West Bengal. Production increased in the steel plants of Tatanagar, Jharkhand, and Burnpur, West Bengal.

To facilitate the development of heavy industries, Bengal and Bihar's coal belts were exploited. Provisions had to now be made for the efficient transportation of materials, such as iron, steel, and coal, as this would